

SpectrumReady Digital Guide

The Autism Benefits Navigator

Every Dollar, Program, and Benefit Your Family Is Entitled To — A Plain-English Guide for Parents of Children with Autism

\$47

SpectrumReady

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Important Notice — Please Read Before Proceeding

Educational Information Only. This guide is for general informational and educational purposes only. It does not constitute legal, financial, or medical advice. The information in this guide is not a substitute for advice from a licensed attorney, financial advisor, healthcare provider, or other qualified professional.

No Professional Relationship. Reading this guide does not create an attorney-client, financial advisor-client, or any other professional relationship between you and SpectrumReady.

Time-Sensitive Information. Government benefit amounts, income thresholds, and program eligibility rules change regularly. Dollar figures and thresholds in this guide reflect information as of 2025. Always verify current amounts and rules directly with the relevant federal or state agency before making any decisions.

Individual Circumstances Vary. Eligibility for the programs discussed depends on your individual circumstances. This guide describes how programs generally work — not whether you or your child specifically qualifies.

Consult Professionals. For decisions about your child's specific situation — including SSI applications, IEP disputes, insurance appeals, or estate planning — consult a qualified special education attorney, disability benefits counselor, or other licensed professional.

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Welcome & How to Use This Guide

If you've recently received your child's autism diagnosis — or if you've had the diagnosis for years and still feel like you're missing something — this guide is for you.

The United States has a patchwork of programs, benefits, and funding sources designed to support families like yours. The problem is that no one hands you a roadmap. Programs are administered by different agencies, have different eligibility rules, and use different jargon. Families often miss out on **thousands of dollars per year** simply because they didn't know to ask.

This guide changes that.

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

1. Read Section 1 first — it gives you the 30,000-foot view
2. Use the Quick-Eligibility table to identify which programs apply to you
3. Go deep on each applicable program in the detailed sections
4. Use the Master Action Checklist at the end to track your progress

Section 1: The Big Picture

Every benefit available to your family falls into one of four buckets:

The Four Categories of Support

- **Federal Entitlement Programs** — If you meet the criteria, you ARE entitled to the benefit by law. No lottery, no waiting list. (SSI, Medicaid base, IDEA)
- **State Waiver Programs** — Medicaid waivers that fund intensive support services. Often have waiting lists, but the services can be life-changing.
- **Federal Assistance Programs** — Income-based support (SNAP, WIC, Section 8, LIHEAP)
- **Savings & Asset Programs** — Protect your child's financial future (ABLE Accounts, Special Needs Trusts)

Quick Eligibility Snapshot

Benefit	Age Limit	Income Test	Waiting List?
SSI	Under 18 (child rules)	Yes (family income)	No
Medicaid	Under 19 (base)	Yes	No
HCBS Waivers	Varies by state	No (usually)	Often yes
Early Intervention	Birth to 3	No	No
Special Education	3–21	No	No
ABLE Account	Under 46 at diagnosis	No	No

Section 2: Supplemental Security Income (SSI)

What Is SSI?

SSI is a federal cash benefit program run by the Social Security Administration. For children with autism, it can provide up to **\$943/month** (2024 rate, adjusted annually).

More importantly: qualifying for SSI usually **automatically qualifies your child for Medicaid**, which covers therapies, medical equipment, and services worth tens of thousands of dollars per year.

Does My Child Qualify?

Your child must meet **both** tests:

Test 1: Disability Test

The SSA evaluates six domains of functioning. To qualify, your child needs either an "extreme" limitation in ONE domain, or "marked" limitations in TWO domains:

1. Acquiring and using information
2. Attending and completing tasks
3. Interacting and relating with others

4. Moving about and manipulating objects
5. Caring for yourself
6. Health and physical well-being

Test 2: Financial Test (Under Age 18)

The SSA counts part of the parents' income. Approximate 2024 income limits:

Household	Approx. Monthly Gross Limit
1 parent, 1 child with disability	~\$4,400/month
2 parents, 1 child with disability	~\$5,500/month
Add per additional child	+~\$400

CRITICAL RULE: THE AGE-18 RESET

When your child turns 18, **parental income is NO LONGER counted**. Almost every young adult with autism should apply for SSI on their 18th birthday — regardless of family income during childhood.

How to Apply — Step by Step

1. **Gather documents:** Birth certificate, Social Security card, medical records, diagnosis report, school IEP/evaluations, proof of household income
2. **Apply:** Online at [SSA.gov/benefits/ssi](https://ssa.gov/benefits/ssi), by phone (1-800-772-1213), or in person at your local Social Security office
3. **Complete the Child Function Report (SSA-3375):** Describe your child's WORST days, not typical days. Be specific. Use the six functional domains above as your framework.

IF YOU ARE DENIED — DO NOT GIVE UP

~60% of initial SSI claims are denied. ~60% of appealed decisions are overturned. You have 60 days to appeal. Consider hiring a disability attorney — most work on contingency (no fee unless you win).

Section 3: Medicaid

Two Paths to Medicaid

- **SSI-Linked:** Most states auto-enroll SSI recipients in Medicaid. Most comprehensive coverage.
- **CHIP/State Medicaid:** Even without SSI, your child may qualify based on family income. Many states cover families up to 200–400% of the Federal Poverty Level.

What Medicaid Must Cover for Children

Under EPSDT (Early and Periodic Screening, Diagnostic and Treatment), Medicaid must cover all **medically necessary** treatment for children under 21:

- ABA therapy (Applied Behavior Analysis)
- Speech therapy, Occupational therapy, Physical therapy
- Psychological evaluations and therapy
- Medical devices and assistive technology
- Dental care, Vision care

Medicaid HCBS Waivers — Where the Real Money Is

HCBS waivers fund services traditional Medicaid doesn't cover:

Service	Example Value
Respite care	30+ hours/month
Day programs / habilitation	\$15,000–\$40,000/year
Supported employment	\$8,000–\$20,000/year
Home modifications	Up to \$10,000
Assistive technology	Varies
Total annual value	\$20,000–\$80,000+

MOST IMPORTANT ACTION IN THIS ENTIRE GUIDE

Most states have HCBS waiver waiting lists of **5–10+ years**. Get on your state's list TODAY — even if your child is young. The list is first-come, first-served. Call your state's Developmental Disabilities agency now.

Section 4: Early Intervention (Birth to Age 3)

Under **IDEA Part C**, every child birth to age 3 with a developmental delay or disability is entitled to free early intervention services — in your home, at no cost.

- Free developmental evaluation (within 45 days of referral)
- Free therapy services (speech, OT, PT, developmental specialist)
- Individualized Family Service Plan (IFSP)

How to access: Call your state's Early Intervention program or dial 2-1-1.

Critical: At age 3, EI ends and children transition to school-based IEP services. A transition meeting should happen around the child's 2½ birthday. Don't let this happen without a plan.

Section 5: Special Education Under IDEA

Under **IDEA Part B** (ages 3–21), your child has the legal right to:

- A **Free Appropriate Public Education (FAPE)**
- An **Individualized Education Program (IEP)**
- Related services (speech, OT, PT, counseling, transportation)
- Education in the **Least Restrictive Environment (LRE)**

The full IEP process is covered in depth in the companion guide "IEP Mastery: The Parent's Advocacy Bible."

Section 6: SNAP (Food Assistance)

2024 Gross Monthly Income Limits

Household Size	Monthly Limit
1	\$1,580
2	\$2,137
3	\$2,694
4	\$3,250
5	\$3,807

Average SNAP benefit: ~\$230/month per person. Apply online through your state's SNAP website.

Autism tip: Households with a disabled member may be able to deduct excess medical/therapy expenses from income for SNAP purposes. Ask about the "medical deduction."

Section 7: WIC

For children under 5 with autism, WIC provides approved foods, formula support for feeding challenges, nutrition counseling, and service referrals. Income limit: 185% of federal poverty level.

Section 8: Housing Assistance

Section 8 Housing Choice Voucher

Subsidizes housing costs — covers the gap between reasonable market rent and 30% of family income. Waitlists are long (2–5+ years). **Apply now** through your local Public Housing Authority (HUD.gov).

Section 9: ABLE Accounts

GAME-CHANGER FOR FINANCIAL PLANNING

ABLE accounts allow you to save up to **\$100,000** without affecting SSI eligibility. Earnings grow tax-free. Anyone can contribute. Open in 15 minutes at **ABLENRC.org**.

Feature	Details
SSI protection limit	Up to \$100,000
Annual contribution limit	\$18,000/year (2024, all sources)
Who qualifies	Autism diagnosis before age 46
Allowed uses	Housing, education, transport, healthcare, technology, recreation
Tax treatment	Contributions after-tax; earnings and withdrawals tax-free

Section 10: Grants for Autism Families

Organization	Grant Amount	Focus Area
Autism Care Today	Up to \$1,500/quarter	Therapy, biomedical treatment
ACT Today!	Varies	ABA therapy, equipment
Doug Flutie Jr. Foundation	Varies	Family support services
Organization for Autism Research	Up to \$1,000	Research participation
Autism Speaks Family Services	Varies	Crisis + emergency assistance

Section 11: Tax Benefits

Medical Expense Deduction

If you itemize deductions, you can deduct medical expenses exceeding 7.5% of AGI. Deductible autism-related expenses include:

- ABA therapy costs not covered by insurance
- Therapy co-pays and deductibles (speech, OT, PT)
- Transportation to medical appointments
- Special education tuition (in some cases)
- Specialized equipment when prescribed

Dependent Care FSA

If your employer offers an FSA, contribute the maximum (\$5,000) to pay for qualifying care with pre-tax dollars — saving 22–37% on those costs.

Master Action Checklist

Do These First — Highest Impact

- ☐ Apply for SSI if family income is below threshold, or if child is approaching 18
- ☐ Confirm Medicaid coverage and verify it covers ABA therapy
- ☐ Get on your state's HCBS waiver waiting list TODAY
- ☐ Open an ABLE account at ABLENRC.org

Within 30 Days

- ☐ Request Early Intervention evaluation if child is under 3

☐ Contact school district to initiate IEP process (ages 3–21)

☐ Check SNAP eligibility and apply if qualified

☐ Apply for WIC if child is under 5 and income qualifies

Within 90 Days

☐ Research private foundation grants and start applying

☐ Review tax situation for medical expense deductions

☐ Apply for Section 8 waiting list

☐ Connect with local autism parent support group

Resources

Resource	Contact
Social Security Administration	SSA.gov 1-800-772-1213
ABLE National Resource Center	ABLENRC.org
Medicaid Information	Medicaid.gov
Autism Speaks Resource Guide	autismspeaks.org/state-resource-guide
Benefits.gov (all federal benefits)	Benefits.gov
Local social services	Dial 2-1-1 or 211.org

SpectrumReady

Empowering autism families with the knowledge they deserve.

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This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute legal, financial, or medical advice. Program rules and benefit amounts are subject to change — verify current information with the relevant agency. For complex situations, consult a qualified professional.

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